

The Game Changers **INDIVIDUALS**

SAMANTAK DAS 43 **READER**, Jadavpur University

THE REAL DEAL

One of the things Samantak Das learnt at the department of English in Jadavpur University is that the role of a teacher extends beyond the assigned tasks of teaching. As a teacher, Das tries to relate the texts to real-life experiences. It is the same impulse that has driven him, at different times, to get involved in relief work in the Sunderbans in the aftermath of Cyclone Aila and work as a volunteer in an NGO for the rehabilitation of rural youth. He believes in thinking out of the box and Rabindranath Tagore fascinates him. "When everybody was going abroad to study law, Tagore sent his son to America to learn agricultural techniques. These examples spur me to do what others find insane," he says. Going to the Sunderbans as a relief worker being one, he supposes. *by Abhijit Dasgupta*

"His teachings engage uncompromisingly with the subject of study."

Sukanta Chaudhuri, Jadavpur University

Education Ph.D in Evolutionary Readings: Darwin, Darwinism and the English Novel in the second half of the 19th Century from Jadavpur University.

Success mantra Love your work and you can change the world.

Usually to be found Daydreaming.



SUVASHIS MULLICK

VADHIRAJAN MURALIDHARAN 43 **FOUNDER**, Sevalaya

THE STRENGTH OF BELIEF



OMAR SHERIFF

If Kasuva, a village 40 km west of Chennai, can boast of not having even a single child out of school, much of the credit goes to Vadhiraajan Muralidharan, a former Tata Consultancy Services' employee who believes in Tamil poet Subramania Bharathi's mantra, that educating one poor child is holier than constructing a thousand temples. Kasuva could have been just another village with no school or hospital, but Muralidharan decided to start an orphanage in this village in 1989, calling it Sevalaya. And what stands today is a 1,000-strong higher secondary school offering free education,

Education B.E. from Indian Institute of Science, Bangalore.

What's next Happy with his school's 100 per cent result in Class XII exams, he now wants to start a university offering free education.

Recent publication *Vaiyath Thalaimai Kol (Lead the World)*, about the leadership qualities of Gandhi and Vivekananda.

an orphanage for 150 students, a craft centre, an old age home, a medical centre and a library. His unique syllabus, BGV, which allows him to integrate the teachings of Bharathi, Gandhi and Vivekananda in the syllabus, has become so popular that Sevalaya teachers are disseminating it in Chennai, Madurai and Trichi prisons.

by Banumathi Krishnaswamy

"He is not only inculcating good values, but also changing the lives of underprivileged children."

R. Nataraj, Former DGP, Prisons